

Sibling rivalry

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Sibling rivalry

by [Iriascend](#)

Summary

But now that [he] was gone he never made any mistakes. His very absence invited imagined mythologies to crystallize into facts.

— an excerpt from "Unearth", by Alicia Elliott

Notes

Remember when I said I never write sad things? I lied.

(You can blame Marns for this fic, as that's who I got the inspiring quote from)

Possible trigger warnings: parental gaslighting, mention of sexual assault

See the end of the work for [more notes](#)

- Inspired by [Requiem](#) by [scandalsavage](#)

“Todd.” The demon brat finally announces his presence. Jason already knew the kid was there, so he doesn’t spook. Though with how good at stealth they all are, he can’t with certainty say he noticed that he was being watched before Damian wanted him to notice. Either way, they’ve both known the other was there for a while now, but neither had acknowledged the other, as is customary for their dysfunctional little family. That can only mean Damian is here to talk about something he doesn’t want to talk about.

Jason only makes a confirmatory grunt, not even looking up at the kid.

“You know the culture of the Alley peasants, don’t you?”

“I *am* one of those peasants, Demon, so choose your next words wisely.”

Damian rolls his eyes; Jason doesn’t spare the kid a glance, and even if he did, the gesture isn’t even visible from under the domino, but the brat makes it obvious — affinity for drama runs in the family, after all.

“I’d like to learn how to improve my rapport with commoners and-”

Jay holds his open hand up to interrupt the boy. “Try again.”

Damian huffs quietly but ultimately *does* take a moment to phrase it better.

“It was pointed out to me that I might be... lacking in my ability to... approach a victim. You’ve been suggested as... an expert in that matter.”

Jay chuckles under his breath and finally looks up. “Did Dickface put you up to this?”

“No.”

“Huh. Then who?”

There’s a beat of silence. “Father.”

Jason’s eyes widen in bewilderment. “B told you to learn social skills from *me*?”

“He didn’t *tell me* to do anything. But he’s been clear about who he thinks was the most efficient Robin in terms of building trust with civilians and gathering intel that way.”

Jay takes a moment to process that information. While he wouldn’t call himself an expert, he *is* the only one that has remotely *any* knowledge about how the streets really are for people. He can imagine that both Dick with his sunshine smiles and Tim with his Batman-wannabe stiffness can be a little off-putting for the ordinary Gothamite.

What he *can*’t imagine is Bruce complimenting him, but he shelves that little conundrum for later. Either way, it can’t hurt to share that kind of attitude with the brat, especially if he sought him out on his own.

“Well, for starters, drop the signature Al Ghul superiority complex. Ain’t nobody wanna talk to someone who thinks they’re better than them.”

“But it’s true.”

“See, that’s where you’re wrong. If you’re better, then why do you need their help gathering intel, hm?”

Damian frowns but doesn’t go for a rebuttal, so Jason grins. Who knows, maybe he will be able to kindle a spark of empathy in the little demon?

Spoiler ambushes him in civvies, in a Walmart parking lot (even the Red Hood has to grab groceries *sometimes*). When he sees her, Jason expects maybe a nod or a wave at most — it’s not like they’re close or anything — but to his surprise, she marches towards him with purpose in her step.

“Did you swear as a kid?” Stephanie asks without as much as a hello.

“No, my first bad word was in Arabic; learned it when Talia stubbed her toe,” he snarks, rolling his eyes. “*Obviously* I swore like a sailor as a kid. We’re both Gotham born’n’raised, what kinda stupid fucking question is that, Blondie?”

She shrugs and makes a non-committal noise, but it’s kind of obvious she’s annoyed. “Bruce got it into his head that I should try to speak more... *elegantly*.”

Jason can’t help but snort. “And he used *me* as a good example?”

“I know, right?” Stephanie sighs. “He went on and on about how you immediately started talking all posh when he took you in and-”

“Did he forget to mention that it was a very deliberate, very materialistically-inspired decision on my side?”

Her eyebrows glide up in surprise and she gestures for Jason to continue.

“He set up a swear jar for me,” he says, massaging his temple at having to recall the annoying memory. “The choice between getting to curse Bruce out and getting to keep my cash was a very easy one. Though I admit I was *very* tempted at times. Even calculated exactly how much I could say before going broke.” He smirks.

Blondie looks at him, bewildered, for a split second, then bursts out laughing. Jason leans in and pats her shoulder with a grin. “Here’s an idea: ask him what he thinks baby me would sound like if I had more money on me.”

She snorts, extending her arm for a fist bump, and he indulges her. “You know what? I might just try, if only to see his face when he realizes.”

His attention is dragged away from his secret mission (which is stealing equipment and escaping before anyone even realizes he's anywhere near the Manor) by the rhythmic clinking of metal coming from another part of the Cave. When he goes to investigate, it turns out to be a very grumpy but also very determined-looking Duke surrounded by a pile of discarded batarangs and various other blades.

Jason waves at him and hollers a hello so the kid doesn't startle. He does anyway.

"Hey, what'cha doin'?" Jay asks, walking over. Duke only spares him a glance, then throws another batarang at the target board 50 feet away. It clangs off it without lodging in it, which only causes Duke to curse. The boy sits down angrily and hides his face in his hands.

"Failing, as you can see," he mumbles in response.

Jason picks up one of the blades lying on a stool nearby, weighs it in his hand, then nonchalantly flings it at the board. It hits the bullseye squarely and Jay grins, pleased with himself. "Practice makes perfect, kid."

"That's easy for *you* to say," Duke snaps. It must've been a truly long and gruelling practice session if he's *this* annoyed. "*The best marksman in Gotham*," he adds in a mocking tone. "Of course you hit it no problem."

Jason quirks an eyebrow, then shrugs. Usually, he'd gladly take the opportunity to boast, but Duke's never crossed him; it'd be a real asshole move to kick him when he's already down. Besides, he's not stupid enough to start beef with *another* Bat when he doesn't have to.

"You just need some time," he says, leaning on a nearby table. "Ya think I had this kinda aim before I was shootin' goons 24/7? Nah. Little Robin Jay preferred a more up-close-and-personal approach for a reason."

He takes another batarang from the pile and lazily flicks it at Duke, who catches it without issue. "So don't let Bruce's yappin' get to you."

"How'd you know-"

Jason looks him up and down. "Who else could be nagging you about it enough to get under your skin? Only a jerk obsessed with being battle-ready, and we've all seen that man's training regimen."

Duke snorts a laugh and nods.

"If you need any advice, I remind ya that Alfred's a trained soldier and is more than willing to share some pointers."

"And Gotham's best marksman isn't?" the boy asks, but the title doesn't have the vitriol it had before. "I mean, you're already here."

Jason grins. "Nope," he says, pocketing a handful of batarangs, just for good measure. "Gotta keep my bad boy lone wolf rep. That being said—" He throws his duffel bag over the

shoulder. Duke doesn't comment on how it's very obviously full of assorted gear and gadgets snatched from around the Cave. "—I'll be skedaddling."

"I'm guessing that if anyone asks, you were never here?"

"See? Already learnin' fast."

Jason struts into Gotham Library like he owns the place. His confidence comes from two reasons: he's there so often he knows the place like the back of his hand, and he donates so much that he might as well really own it. Besides, it's Barbie's turf, so it feels like because of them both being vaguely Bat-adjacent, he's at least welcome there, unlike many other places in the city.

Like every Thursday, he's here to replace the books he's finished, but today it's not the only reason. He also has intel to trade with Babs; given its rather sensitive nature, she requested he show up in person and they swap USB sticks instead of sending the data over the wire.

Before he gets to Barbara's desk, though, he has to do a double-take. He's pretty sure he's imagining it—nope, that really is Tim Drake hunched over a textbook, surrounded by a dozen more.

Jay approaches him with a smug smirk slowly crawling onto his lips.

"You look like shit, Pretender," he says, and Tim jolts up from his study. "Which says a lot given you usually already look like death warmed over."

"Fuck off," Tim says in an unconventional display of crassness. He rubs his eyes, takes a sip out of the coffee mug nearby, and goes back to reading.

Jason looks over the text and frowns. "What the fuck do you need history of art for?"

"I knew you're not the brightest tool in the shed, but I didn't think *'fuck off'* would be beyond your understanding."

Jason chuckles, pulls up a nearby chair and sits at Tim's table. It elicits a pained groan from the younger man.

"The stick up your ass is unusually long today. What gives? Didn't think any kind of art heist plot could get under your skin like that."

Tim sighs, and slowly closes the textbook. "It's not for a case."

"Then what's up?"

"Long story short: I signed up for uni one night while on three hours of sleep, and the press announced it publicly before I came to my senses and cancelled."

"And now you gotta keep up the appearances," Jason supplies, whistling. "You poor bastard."

“I couldn’t care less for appearances, actually, I have a publicist for that. It’s just... it’s a matter of pride.”

“Pride?”

“Well, I did it all because B was being an ass, going on and on about your *straight As* and *perfect school record*. I thought that if I graduated from Gotham U, it’d beat your 8th-grade honors.”

Jason blinks staring at Tim once. Twice. Then bursts into laughter, only to immediately try to silence himself by stuffing a fist into his mouth. They *are* in a library, after all.

“You—” he manages through the spasms, “You signed up for uni, despite having a full-time job at WE and the nightly hobby and your California team and whatnot, just to rub it in Bruce’s face?”

He really can’t believe how competitive Drake can get.

“... basically, yeah.” Tim shrugs. “You have no idea how annoying he can get when he’s talking about you.”

“Oh, I think I have an inkling. You’re not the first person to tell me B has incited some sibling rivalry spirit in ya and, well,” Jason gives Tim one of his signature shit-eating grins, “it looks like in this case I’m still winning.”

Tim snarls at him briefly. “That attitude is exactly why I told you to fuck off. Don’t you have anything better to do?”

“Yea, Barbie’s waiting for me. Good luck with the exams! Just a reminder, though: I had way more time than you to get my grades up. Don’t beat yourself up if you lose this round.”

Tim kicks his leg under the table and that prompts Jason to stand up, still chuckling quietly. The suggestion he gave him is honest, though — as much as he wants to see just how little sleep Tim can function on, he knows that Pretender’s life is way busier and higher-stakes than baby Jay’s was. University ain’t middle school, either. If Tim manages to get through even a single semester, he’ll be impressed.

Barbara’s sitting at her desk as she usually does at this time of the day. Jason politely waits for her to finish checking out a patron, then approaches the desk; her face is more sour than usual.

“Rough day?” Jason asks, rummaging through his backpack.

“Stop harassing Tim.”

He rolls his eyes. “Was civil, I promise. Just surprised he’s going through with the college thing.”

She looks him up and down, and it seems that she accepts his assurance because she goes back to typing at her keyboard. Compared to what she uses in her *real* job, this setup looks almost... archaic.

“Well, Bruce has been a pain for everybody. Pushing us like he doesn’t realise we’re, you know, *busy*.”

“Even you?”

Barbara doesn’t grace him with a reply. “You have what I need?” she asks instead.

“Do you?”

She scoffs. He grins and puts a stack of books on the counter. The data stick he promised her is laying inconspicuously on top of one of the wider tomes.

Barbie stares at the books for a moment before pulling them down to her side of the desk. “I honestly have no idea how you do it.”

Jason already has the drive that *she* snuck into his hand, so he’s pretty sure it’s not about the amazing display of sleight of hand. “Do what?”

“Read so much. Most of us barely have time to sleep.”

He chuckles. “So do I, but there are things more important than sleep,” he snarks, then shrugs. “Truth be told, I mostly read during stakeouts, however weird that sounds.”

She sighs. “Yeah, don’t think I’m doing *that* anytime soon.”

Jason doesn’t say anything in reply, in hopes of drawing her into saying more. Now that he admitted he doesn’t magically have more hours in the day than she does, it seems she’s more willing to talk because she continues.

“The other day Bruce had the audacity to say I don’t read enough fiction. That 13-year-old you was a better conversationalist.” Barbara sneers in annoyance. “Like, Bruce, unlike you I have an actual *job* and I also run the intel for three and a half teams! I don’t have *time* for reading books.”

“Even if you’re around them all day,” Jason comments with a smug smirk. She sends him a sharp look and he grins sheepishly. “I know, I know, you’re at work, there’s shit to do, no time to sit back and read a book.”

“Get out of my hair before I post deep fakes of RH porn online.”

The way she says it makes Jason feel she is irritated enough that she might just do it. He salutes her goodbye and backs out silently.

Cassandra approaches him as silently as she always does, and it takes all of Jason's self-control and quick thinking not to jump when she embraces him. God bless that he isn't armed, or he might've seriously hurt her.

"What'd I tell ya about sneaking up on me like that?" he growls at her, but there's no real bite behind it. "I almost punched you."

Cass doesn't respond. Instead, she reaches for his free arm and wraps it around herself. That immediately shifts Jason's train of thought — something must be *really* wrong. Sure, she comes to him for comfort sometimes ('cause Dick, for all the support he gives, doesn't know how to shut up, and Cass still doesn't do well with words), but not this out of the blue. The fact that she took the trip across Gotham just to find him means she's even more upset than she looks.

The girl slowly shakes her head and hides her face in his chest. "Quiet," she pleads, voice barely a whisper. Jason obliges. He pulls her closer and sits them down on a nearby bench. They stay like that for a good while — Joe will be disappointed when he doesn't show up for his traditional beer at the pub at the end of the week, but it doesn't matter now. Jason doesn't say anything, just pats her back in silence, and gradually, she relaxes slightly; enough to look up at him, at least.

"Thank you," she finally says, her voice soft and weak.

"Wanna tell me what got ya like this?" His question is one part worry, one part anger. Being protective over the objectively most badass person in their little vigilante clique is stupid, but it's exactly because of situations like this that they all have a soft spot for Cass.

"People."

He's confused for a moment, but then it dawns on him it's about the time of year for Wayne Foundation's annual charity gala. "Had to fill your quota of looking like a high-society doll, huh?"

She nods.

Jason sighs and starts petting her back and hair again. He's been there himself back in the day, of course, and he knows it's a hassle, but it shouldn't get her *this* burnt-out...

"Words, words, words," she elaborates. "Too much."

"Why didn't you leave earlier?" It seems like the obvious solution and it's not like Cass isn't a master of silent escapes.

"Bruce," Cass says and shivers slightly. Jason instantly scowls.

"The bastard told you that you couldn't leave the gala?" he asks, slowly, trying to reign in his anger.

She shakes her head. "People *talk* if you hide a lot. So I didn't hide."

“And now you’re exhausted.”

Cass just hugs him tighter. “Didn’t—... Bruce said you did it a lot. No problems. So I thought I can too.”

Jason sighs and pats her back again. “Want to stay at my place for tonight?” he says, making sure to sound as gentle as humanly possible. He’s angry, yes, but yelling at B can wait. Right now, he needs to help her.

Jason goes out early the next morning, leaving Cass still asleep on his couch, wrapped up in all the blankets he could find because he doesn’t have a weighted one. Not eating at least a bite of breakfast before departure makes him even more irritable, and he breaks fifteen different traffic laws on his way towards Bristol, but he can’t find the fucks to care about any of it.

He storms into the Cave — eyes tinted green, knuckles white and ready to punch the bastard in the face — just in time to walk straight into a screaming match between B and Dickhead.

He’d enjoy the show if it wasn’t in the way of his *own* screaming.

“I can’t believe you let this happen, Dick!” Bruce doesn’t have to gesture to the big screen of the Batcomputer for Jason to know what he’s talking about. The digitized first page of Gotham Daily displayed there is mostly taken up by a picture of Dick’s half-naked ass.

Yesterday’s gala must’ve been *fun*.

“Like *you’re* the one to talk, Bruce! Pot, kettle,” Dick sneers.

“I never got caught by the press. Everything that’s published is precisely crafted. *You* just got ambushed. What does that say about your skills as a vigilante? What does that say about *the Waynes*?”

“It’s not like it’s my fault! What did you want me to do, punch civilians when they get handsy? There were five drunk girls trying to get it on with me in the middle of a crowd, it’s a miracle I only flashed people my underwear!”

Jason makes a quiet agreeing murmur. Dickhead’s right; what *else* could he have done? Besides, if anything, Bruce should be *comforting* his golden boy after he got publicly groped, not *yelling* at him.

“I never had to cover up *Jason’s* public indecency!”

“BECAUSE HE *DIED AT FIFTEEN*, BRUCE!” Dick immediately retorts.

A beat of silence breaks up the screaming as it dawns on them both what exactly Dick had just blurted out.

“At least he wouldn’t talk back to me like that,” Bruce says, his sharp gaze piercing through Dick as if expecting him to fall to his knees and beg for forgiveness.

That’s the last straw. Jason finally steps in.

“I would,” he says loudly, approaching them in long, decisive strides, drawing their attention fully to him. “And I will. What the fuck, old man?! You’re getting senile. Dick’s right. And so is everyone else. I did all the things you complain others are doing, and then some.”

Bruce looks at him and frowns. “That’s not how I remember it,” he says, and that’s when Jason realizes. None of them — including Jason himself — can appease Bruce.

The truth doesn’t matter.

There’s no competing with a memory.

End Notes

Big thanks to [Miss Tuesday](#) for amazing and quick beta! <3

The full quote that inspired this (only here because it's a little spoilery for this fic):
"...his youthful imperfections [were] buffed to a glossy sheen. ... Her mistakes were no more notable than any kid her age. But now that [he] was gone he never made any mistakes. His very absence invited imagined mythologies to crystallize into facts. ... The truth didn't matter. There was no competing with a memory. "

If you wanna say hi or talk with me, you can find me over on [Tumblr](#) :)

This story is part of the [LLF Comment Project](#), which was created to improve communication between readers and authors. This author invites and appreciates feedback, including:

- Short comments
- Long comments
- Questions
- "<3" as extra kudos
- Reader-reader interaction
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If you'd like to go the extra mile, try answering some of these questions in your comment:

- Did any particular sentence stand out to you? Do you have a favourite phrase from the fic, did you like the way something was worded?
- Did anything make you laugh?
- Has the fic caused an emotional reaction? Touched your heart, made you *feel*?
- Was there any particular scene that you liked?
- Have you noticed any recurring themes or motifs? Any Easter eggs?

This author sees and cherishes all comments, and tries to reply to them all, but may not manage to due to anxiety.

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